



A squatting position This puts gravity on your side. Your nurse and birth partner can help support your weight.

Your birth partner's **support and encouragement** are hugely beneficial now, giving you strength to bear down and push.

Q If giving birth in a squatting position is helpful, why are women often shown lying down on their back?

There have been times in our history during which women were encouraged to lie on their backs on a bed to give birth. It is now more usual for doctors and hospitals to encourage women to do what feels right for them. It is generally acknowledged that lying "supine" is not necessarily the most comfortable or effective position to deliver a baby. There are other positions that can be more effective such as side lying, squatting, and resting on all fours. With more upright positions, gravity can give you a helping hand to keep your labor progressing. In this way, upright positions could reduce the chances of your needing an episiotomy or an assisted birth, although

they don't improve the risk of tearing. Birthing chairs and stools (see box, above right) provide similar benefits.

Lying down can be restful, but without gravity on your side labor may be slower. You will also need to be propped up so that you don't put too much pressure on your blood vessels, which could restrict the blood flow to both you and your baby. Lying down may make it easier for a doctor to give you an internal examination and to monitor the health of your baby because you can be hooked up to a stationary heart monitor. However, the latter can be done from a sitting position, too.

An advantage of giving birth in a bed is that as soon as your baby is born, a nurse can place him on your belly without you having to maneuver yourself into a comfortable and safe position, which can be especially tricky if you feel a bit unsteady after the effort of birth.

Q I'm considering a water birth. Is it safe to birth in the water or should I get out when pushing?

Yes, it is perfectly safe. Although many parents-to-be worry that a water birth poses a danger of drowning for the baby, in fact there is no known increased risk—for drowning or any other complication—compared with babies who are born out of the water. As your baby emerges into the pool, he will continue to be "fed" by the umbilical cord, giving your doctor plenty of time to lift him from the water before the breathing reflex kicks in. If you're worried, you can get out of the water to give birth.

Q I'd like to give birth lying down on my side. Is this possible?

Yes, this is completely possible. In fact, if you don't like the idea of expending effort to retain a squatting, lunging, or standing position during the second stage of labor, lying on your side